

Neither was expected. What's next? Obviously, we don't know. If it's a big, nasty surprise, we're hope we're not in Bethesda, Maryland, when it comes.

Why? Because the supermarkets would be cleaned out in minutes, the gas stations would run dry, and we'd be trapped in a hostile environment, depending on the kindness of strangers and the competence of government officials.

What do you need to survive a disaster? First, you need access to water. As we've seen in Japan, even the most developed and sophisticated infrastructure in the world can collapse when it is struck by an earthquake and a tsunami. Public water pipes break. It can take weeks or months to replace them, assuming the government and local utilities are still functioning.

That's why it's a good idea to have your own private source of water: a spring; a well; a small, clean stream. Failing that, you should have enough water stocked up to last at least a couple of weeks.

Then you need to worry about food. How long could you live on what is in your refrigerator? We could make it for about 24 hours. Then it would be slim pickings. And what if the supermarket were closed? What if the 7-11 were stripped bare? What if trucks couldn't make deliveries?

Well, surely the president would call out the National Guard. Yes, if everything is working as it should, and the National Guard doesn't have more important things to worry about.

Just as a precaution, you should maintain a stock of canned goods and dried food. Enough to last two weeks is the minimum. A month is better. Then, rotate your stock—don't leave it untouched for so long it goes bad.

Having an inventory of basic foodstuffs and water is essential. It will keep you calm. You won't be in desperate straits. It will give you time to carefully assess the situation and choose your best option. You won't do something rash.

But what if the breakdown stays broken down for months? War . . . hyperinflation . . . a full collapse of the financial or political system . . . the crisis could take many months to run its course. In the meantime, supply and distribution systems may be severely or completely interrupted. You need a strategy.